

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Landscaping and Grounds English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Landscape crew members, groundskeepers, lawn-service workers, and grounds assistants.

All properties, people, quantities, incidents, and service arrangements are fictional language practice, not horticultural, pesticide, equipment, irrigation, tree-work, safety, or property-law training. Do not infer plant treatments, application rates, pruning methods, site safety, or legal boundaries from these examples. Refer technical suitability, hazardous conditions, property questions, prices, and job changes to the responsible qualified people.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Confirming the booked grounds work

Clarify an extra task without dismissing the customer's request.

02 Clarifying access and property limits

Decline an unconfirmed extension while preserving the agreed job.

03 Clarifying appearance and plant requests

Establish which plant and which visual concern the customer means.

04 Explaining a weather-related change

Give a useful weather update without making unsupported safety or scheduling judgments.

05 Reporting site observations without diagnosis

Give a specific site report that a qualified colleague can assess.

06 Checking materials and requested quantities

Describe two discrepancies without converting a visual guess into approval.

07 Responding to finish and cleanup concerns

Acknowledge a visible shortfall without accepting unrelated scope changes.

08 Handing over unfinished grounds work

Transfer completed tasks, deferred questions, and customer contact needs accurately.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Confirming the booked grounds work

Clarify an extra task without dismissing the customer's request.

CASE

Oak Court's work order includes front-lawn mowing and path leaf clearance. Resident asks for rear-hedge shaping. Hedges are excluded from today's booking; office can review a separate request, with no price or date confirmed.

Teach this move

A recurring service does not automatically include every grounds task on every visit.

Vocabulary to check: work order, service area, exclusion, recurring visit.

Model response

Today's work order covers the front lawn and leaf clearance from the path. Rear-hedge shaping isn't included in this visit. Is that an additional request you would like the office to review? I'll keep the new hedge request separate from the booked work so we don't imply that its price or timing has already been agreed.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. Specific tasks prevent a broad description from becoming an unintended promise.

Second-round challenge

The resident asks whether requesting the extra task guarantees it today. Distinguish request from booking.

Language-check answers

1. B - additional Correct. The hedge adds to the listed work.
2. C - according to Correct. 'According to' links tasks to the schedule.

05 • Conversations

1. The rear hedge is a new request - At Oak Court, a worker checks the resident's expectation against today's work order.
2. The annual task is not every visit - A grounds worker clarifies a customer's seasonal-service expectation.
3. A request from someone who is not the contact - A worker checks a tenant's extra-work request at an office property.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two tasks under the word tidy

Work order: clear leaves from front steps. Customer says 'tidy the front' and also means reshape shrubs. Shrub work is not booked.

Role A: Worker: separate cleanup from plant work.

Role B: Customer: ask about both, but accept a separate scope review.

Possible opening: When you say tidy, do you mean the leaves or the shrub shape?

Success checks

- Name the included leaf clearance.
- Describe the shrub request separately.
- Avoid quoting an unconfirmed price.

Add a complication: Customer assumes both tasks have the same price.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Clarifying access and property limits

Decline an unconfirmed extension while preserving the agreed job.

CASE

Customer asks for clearing beyond a rear fence, saying the strip is probably theirs. Work plan ends at the fence; ownership is unconfirmed. Worker can flag the request to the office but cannot decide the property boundary.

Teach this move

A fence, hedge, or informal statement may not establish the legal property limit. Practice referral, not boundary advice.

Vocabulary to check: access arrangement, property boundary, no-work area, site contact.

Model response

The current work plan ends at the rear fence. I understand you believe the strip beyond it belongs to you, but that boundary hasn't been confirmed for this job. We can continue with the agreed area and refer the additional strip to the office. I can't extend today's work on the basis of 'probably.'

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The response does not make an ownership judgment.

Second-round challenge

A neighbor offers permission verbally. Keep ownership and job authorization questions with the responsible office.

Language-check answers

1. A - limit Correct. The fence marks the plan's agreed work limit.
2. A - awaiting inclusion confirmation Correct. Inclusion of the additional area is still unconfirmed.

05 • Conversations

1. Beyond the rear fence - A grounds worker responds to an uncertain property-area request.
2. A locked gate is an access issue - A worker calls the named site contact about a closed service entrance.
3. A marked no-work area - A worker confirms an excluded flower bed with a facilities contact.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 • Say it: second scenario | Permission for access, not extra work

Building contact authorizes access through a side gate to reach the booked rear lawn. A resident assumes this adds side-bed work; it does not.

Role A: Worker: distinguish route of access from service area.

Role B: Resident: request side-bed work separately.

Possible opening: Does using the side gate change which beds are included?

Success checks

- Confirm the access arrangement.
- Keep rear lawn as booked.
- Refer side-bed work as an extra request.

Add a complication: Resident points to the gate permission as proof of added scope.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Clarifying appearance and plant requests

Establish which plant and which visual concern the customer means.

CASE

Customer says 'tidy the tall one' beside two plants near the entrance. They mean the rosemary beside the left flower bed, not the specimen magnolia. A qualified lead must review whether and how any pruning fits the job.

Teach this move

Clarifying a preference is not diagnosing plant health or prescribing pruning.

Vocabulary to check: hedge line, flower bed, specimen plant, pruning request.

Model response

When you say 'the tall one,' do you mean the rosemary beside the left flower bed or the specimen magnolia near the door? Please identify the plant and describe the appearance you want. I can relay that request to the lead for review; identifying the plant doesn't by itself confirm a suitable pruning method or booking.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. Explicit location and identity avoid an ambiguous gesture.

Second-round challenge

The customer asks for a guarantee the plant will flower more. Refer that outcome question to the qualified lead.

Language-check answers

1. C - clarifying Correct. 'For clarifying' describes the helpful action.
2. D - preference Correct. The discussion clarified the customer's desired appearance.

05 • Conversations

1. Which tall plant? - A worker clarifies an appearance request beside the entrance.
2. A photo shows a preference, not a method - A grounds worker discusses a reference image with a customer.
3. The bed name changed in the customer's description - A worker and customer establish which planting area a request concerns.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 • Say it: second scenario | Keeping a focal plant distinct

Customer asks about the low shrubs beside a fountain. The central specimen plant is excluded. Customer describes the desired appearance as 'less crowded'; no method is agreed.

Role A: Worker: clarify which plants and the visual concern.

Role B: Customer: preserve the central specimen and refer methods to the lead.

Possible opening: Does less crowded refer to the surrounding shrubs or the central plant?

Success checks

- Identify surrounding shrubs only.
- Preserve the specimen exclusion.
- Do not turn a preference into a removal instruction.

Add a complication: A coworker interprets the phrase as a definite removal request.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Explaining a weather-related change

Give a useful weather update without making unsupported safety or scheduling judgments.

CASE

Lead has paused Cedar Court's planned outdoor work because of site conditions after rain. Office suggests Thursday, but crew availability is unconfirmed. Customer has an event Friday. Worker can relay the event and request a scheduling update by Wednesday noon.

Teach this move

Relay the lead's decision and the actual booking status. Avoid declaring a site suitable yourself.

Vocabulary to check: weather delay, rescheduled visit, service interval, provisional date.

Model response

The lead has paused today's outdoor work because of the site conditions after rain. Thursday is a provisional date, not a confirmed replacement visit. I understand your event is Friday. I'll pass that deadline to the office and request an update by Wednesday noon, without promising that all work can be completed before the event.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision prevents a suggestion from becoming a guarantee.

Second-round challenge

Thursday becomes unavailable. Explain the change and ask the office for actual alternatives instead of defending the earlier suggestion.

Language-check answers

1. D - provisional Correct. It is proposed but unconfirmed.
2. D - update Correct. Wednesday noon is the requested communication deadline.

05 • Conversations

1. Thursday remains provisional - A worker updates Cedar Court's customer about a paused visit.
2. A visit moved, not removed - A worker clarifies a weather message with a customer.
3. Only one part of the visit changed - A worker explains a limited change to a facilities contact.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 • Say it: second scenario | The proposed date conflicts with access

Office proposes Monday after a weather delay. Property contact says gate access is unavailable Monday but confirmed Tuesday morning; crew availability Tuesday is unknown.

Role A: Worker: pass on the access constraint.

Role B: Customer: offer Tuesday access, not a crew booking.

Possible opening: Is Tuesday confirmed for access only, or for the crew as well?

Success checks

- Separate access from crew availability.
- Keep Monday unsuitable for this access arrangement.
- Ask the office to confirm an actual replacement visit.

Add a complication: Customer tells a neighbor the crew is booked Tuesday.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Reporting site observations without diagnosis

Give a specific site report that a qualified colleague can assess.

CASE

Worker sees standing water beside the east bed near irrigation zone 3 at 09:15. Cause is unknown; no system check has occurred. Customer asks if a pipe is broken. Grounds lead can arrange review.

Teach this move

Location and timing make an observation useful. Do not turn a visible condition into technical diagnosis.

Vocabulary to check: irrigation zone, standing water, bare patch, site observation.

Model response

At 09:15 I noticed standing water beside the east bed near zone three. I haven't checked the irrigation system, so I can't say a pipe is broken or identify the cause. I'll report the location and time to the grounds lead and ask for a review. The observation is confirmed; the explanation is not.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The statement stays within observed facts.

Second-round challenge

A neighbor says it always happens after rain. Attribute that report without treating it as a verified cause.

Language-check answers

1. A - a site observation Correct. Visible pooling is an observation, not a verified cause.
2. A - the neighbor's reported experience Correct. The account is attributed to its actual source.

05 • Conversations

1. Water near zone three - A worker reports a site observation to a customer.
2. A bare patch does not identify a treatment - A customer asks a grounds worker about a lawn observation.
3. An observation was assigned to the wrong bed - A worker corrects a site-report location with the grounds lead.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A damp path reported by someone else

Reception reports dampness near the west path at 08:00. Worker arrives at 10:00 and does not see it. No cause or safety assessment is established.

Role A: Worker: distinguish a reported earlier condition from your present observation.

Role B: Receptionist: confirm time and location, not cause.

Possible opening: Was the dampness present when you saw it at eight, or are you describing it now?

Success checks

- Attribute the 08:00 report.
- State what was observed at 10:00.
- Refer review without declaring the path safe or diagnosing cause.

Add a complication: Someone summarizes the path as always wet.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Checking materials and requested quantities

Describe two discrepancies without converting a visual guess into approval.

CASE

A job lists eight bags of dark mulch for the front beds. Delivery has six bags; the label describes natural brown. Customer's approved sample was dark. Worker cannot approve substitution or promise coverage; office will query supplier.

Teach this move

A bag count does not establish coverage, and a similar-looking material is not automatically the agreed material.

Vocabulary to check: mulch, delivery quantity, material sample, coverage area.

Model response

The job lists eight bags of dark mulch for the front beds. Six bags arrived, and their label says natural brown. We have both a quantity difference and a material-description difference. Could the office check those against the approved sample and supplier order before we describe this delivery as matching the job?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The wording names both differences.

Second-round challenge

The supplier calls brown 'close enough.' Keep the substitution decision with the responsible office and customer.

Language-check answers

1. A - material description Correct. Natural brown differs from the agreed dark material description.
2. B - establish Correct. 'Establish' means demonstrate or confirm.

05 • Conversations

1. Six bags in a different color - A worker discusses a material discrepancy with the office.
2. The sample is not the entire delivery - A customer asks a worker about materials arriving for review.
3. Front beds, not the whole garden - A worker clarifies the area covered by a material estimate.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Delivery units changed between messages

Office order lists twelve bags. Supplier message says three bundles of four bags. Worker has confirmed three outer bundles, not opened contents.

Role A: Worker: clarify units and verification limits.

Role B: Office clerk: request the packing breakdown before calling it short.

Possible opening: Are those three bundles or three individual bags?

Success checks

- Explain the listed three-by-four relationship.
- Confirm only observed bundles.
- Keep inner bag count unverified until checked.

Add a complication: Customer thinks three means nine bags are missing.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Responding to finish and cleanup concerns

Acknowledge a visible shortfall without accepting unrelated scope changes.

CASE

Customer says path cleanup was incomplete after today's front-lawn visit. Worker can see clippings beside the front steps, within the listed cleanup area. Rear patio is excluded. Lead can organize the missed front cleanup; no wider task is agreed.

Teach this move

An apology can name the actual missed work. It need not imply that every requested extra was included.

Vocabulary to check: finish standard, clippings, debris removal, walk-through.

Model response

You're right that clippings remain beside the front steps, which are part of today's listed path cleanup. I'm sorry that area was missed. I'll ask the lead to arrange completion of that specific cleanup and confirm the plan with you. The rear patio is a separate request, so let's keep it distinct from this missed task.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The response acknowledges the customer's supported observation.

Second-round challenge

The customer says an apology means all cleanup is free. Do not invent prices or decide the separate request.

Language-check answers

1. B - included Correct. It was part of the agreed task.
2. C - separate Correct. It is distinct from correcting the missed front area.

05 • Conversations

1. Clippings beside the front steps - A customer and worker review a missed part of the cleanup.
2. Debris from another contractor - A customer asks a grounds worker about a pile beside the job area.
3. Finished on one side, not both - A worker corrects an overbroad completion statement during a walk-through.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A bin left outside the requested area

Work order includes collecting leaf bags from the front path. Bags are collected, but one empty customer bin remains by the steps instead of its agreed side-store location.

Role A: Worker: acknowledge the specific incomplete finish detail.

Role B: Customer: request correction, not a wider cleanup.

Possible opening: The bags are collected; is the remaining concern the bin's agreed location?

Success checks

- Distinguish completed bag collection from bin-location issue.
- Name the agreed side-store location.
- Ask the lead to arrange the correction.

Add a complication: A colleague marks the whole visit failed.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Handing over unfinished grounds work

Transfer completed tasks, deferred questions, and customer contact needs accurately.

CASE

At Pine Court, front-path leaves are cleared. Rear-bed review was deferred by the lead; no planting or diagnosis was done. Customer requests a callback about that bed before Friday. Office contact Ava owns scheduling; a visit date is not booked.

Teach this move

A completion note can close today's visit while retaining an outstanding follow-up.

Vocabulary to check: completion note, follow-up visit, seasonal task, outstanding item.

Model response

The front-path leaf clearance at Pine Court is complete. The rear-bed review remains deferred; no planting or diagnosis was carried out there. Ava, the customer requests a callback before Friday about that bed. Please take the scheduling follow-up and confirm the callback arrangement. The request should not be recorded as a booked return visit yet.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The distinction prevents unfinished work being lost.

Second-round challenge

The next crew sees 'visit complete.' Explain which task is complete and what the office still owns.

Language-check answers

1. D - postponed Correct. Deferred means postponed, not canceled or completed.
2. A - contact Correct. The callback arranges communication, not a site visit.

05 • Conversations

1. Front path complete, rear-bed review deferred - A worker hands Pine Court's unresolved request to office contact Ava.
2. A seasonal request in the wrong month - A worker and office clerk clarify a customer's future request.

3. The next crew needs the customer's exact limit - A departing worker hands a customer preference to an incoming colleague.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An unanswered question at a completed visit

Today's mowing and path clearance are complete. Customer asked about replacing a shrub, but the lead has not reviewed it. Office contact Ben accepts the query.

Role A: Worker: distinguish completed work from the new plant request.

Role B: Ben: take the query; do not book replacement before review.

Possible opening: Does the completion note show the shrub question as a request, not an agreed replacement?

Success checks

- Correct the unsupported replacement wording.
- Preserve completed tasks.
- Name Ben as query owner and leave outcome open.

Add a complication: A short note says 'replace shrub next visit.'

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All properties, people, quantities, incidents, and service arrangements are fictional language practice, not horticultural, pesticide, equipment, irrigation, tree-work, safety, or property-law training. Do not infer plant treatments, application rates, pruning methods, site safety, or legal boundaries from these examples. Refer technical suitability, hazardous conditions, property questions, prices, and job changes to the responsible qualified people.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Grounds Maintenance Workers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/building-and-grounds-cleaning/grounds-maintenance-workers.htm>

OSHA: Landscape and Horticultural Services Overview

<https://www.osha.gov/landscaping>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.